

A first session with Vi\$ion

A 30-minute pilot for adult learners. Use fictional households throughout. These materials support an early usability and learning pilot; they are not a validated assessment.

The purpose

Help each learner read a current financial picture, explain one choice and recognize its consequences. A large income or a high game score alone does not establish financial health. Different households can face similar pressure, with very different resources and constraints.

Time	Activity	Listen for
0-3 min	Welcome and short baseline questions	Comfort, expectations, any access needs
3-9 min	Read the two household pictures on page 2	Income, obligations, remaining dollars and reserves
9-13 min	Make a Debtbreak plan using page 3	Every available dollar assigned once
13-23 min	Play, pause and discuss one or more paydays	A named target; savings used intentionally
23-28 min	Repeat the scenario questions and debrief	A reason linked to a financial fact
28-30 min	Collect one clear moment and one confusing moment	A concrete improvement to the experience

Say this at the start

“You do not need to share your own finances. We will use made-up households. You can pause, skip a question or stop. We are testing the game and the explanation. You are helping us find what is clear and what needs work.”

Keep Level 1 before Level 2

Level 1: What are the current facts in each corner? What decision follows from those facts?

Level 2: How will a change in one corner affect the others? Introduce this only after the learner can read the starting picture.

Different incomes. What remains?

Two fictional households. All monthly income is take-home pay. Living expenses exclude required debt payments and payroll deductions already removed from income.

Current picture	Everyday paycheck	Bigger paycheck
Take-home income / month	\$3,000	\$9,000
Living costs / month	\$1,800	\$6,000
Required debt payments / month	\$600	\$2,400
Accessible emergency reserves	\$1,200	\$4,200
Asset resale value	\$20,000	\$200,000
Total debt	\$12,000	\$170,000
Credit score	660	760

Read before you decide

1. After living costs and required debt payments, how many dollars remain each month?

Everyday paycheck: _____ Bigger paycheck: _____

2. How long would the current reserves cover living costs plus required debt payments?

Everyday paycheck: _____ Bigger paycheck: _____

3. What do you still need to understand before calling either household financially healthy?

The asset and debt totals are a simplified snapshot. In a fuller review, identify which debts are secured against which assets, ownership shares, selling costs and access to funds.

Give each dollar a job.

Debtbreak Level 1 uses a simplified financial period. One combat period lasts 30 seconds. Clearing both debts resolves the level; a payday is a continuation of the same level.

This period	Amount
Take-home income	\$4,000
Other living costs	-\$3,000
Required debt payments	-\$200
Available to allocate	\$800

The balances below are after this period's minimum payments. Do not subtract those payments a second time. Opening reserves are \$400. A \$600 essential repair is disclosed at the end of period 1; reserves cover it first. Any shortfall is due next period under the game's interest-free practice arrangement.

Account	Balance	APR	Required payment
Loan	\$400	8%	\$40 / month
Card	\$2,600	24%	\$160 / month

Make your plan

To reserves: \$_____ + debt ammunition: \$_____ = \$800.

Reserve Strike spending limit: \$_____ (choose \$0 to disable).

Strategy: Snowball / Avalanche. First target: _____

Predict, then execute

What debt will remain if the plan is executed? _____

What reserves will remain after the repair? _____

What fact explains your choice? _____

Landed shots spend debt ammunition. A deliberate Reserve Strike spends savings. Missing a shot does not spend the debt budget. Minimum payments continue on the other open account. Empty ammunition means defend until payday.

Read the result, not the rank.

Use these answers to support a conversation. Ask learners to explain the fact behind their answer.

Households: the same remaining dollars

Everyday: $\$3,000 - \$1,800 - \$600 = \600 remaining. $\$1,200 / \$2,400 = 0.5$ months of reserves.

Bigger: $\$9,000 - \$6,000 - \$2,400 = \600 remaining. $\$4,200 / \$8,400 = 0.5$ months of reserves.

Required debt payments are 20% and about 26.7% of take-home income. All listed living costs plus required payments are 80% and about 93.3%. Label these as ratios to take-home income, not conventional lender DTI. The two ratios answer different questions.

Assets, debt, income flexibility, household needs and credit differ. Equal remaining cash does not mean equal circumstances. No single number is a complete picture.

Two strategies, one \$400 extra-payment budget

After the extra payment	Snowball	Avalanche
Target	Loan: smallest balance	Card: highest APR
Remaining balances	Loan \$0; Card \$2,600	Loan \$400; Card \$2,200
Next interest estimate	\$52.00	\$46.67
Required monthly payment freed	\$40	\$0

Interest illustration: remaining balance x APR / 12, rounded to cents, before the next minimum payments. It matches the game's simple monthly assumptions. Real accounts can accrue interest differently. Do not present this one-period comparison as a full-life payoff calculation.

Protection working

Opening reserves $\$400 +$ a $\$400$ deposit = $\$800$. After a $\$600$ repair, $\$200$ remains if no reserves were spent on strikes. The reserve decrease is the protection working. If $\$200$ had first funded strikes, the repair would leave $\$0$. Ask what should happen at the next payday.

Credit communication prompt: "If a payment may be late, what should you ask the creditor?" Look for early contact, available options, costs, changed due dates, credit reporting and written terms. Assistance or a score improvement is not guaranteed.

Measure understanding separately.

Arcade skill, reading comfort and device performance can affect play. Record those separately from financial understanding.

Five short prompts, before and after

1. With take-home income \$3,000, living costs \$1,800 and required debt payments \$600, what remains? [\$600]
2. Accessible reserves are \$1,200 and those monthly costs total \$2,400. How many months are covered? [0.5]
3. Does asset resale value automatically equal accessible emergency savings? [No]
4. What does a credit record help a lender understand? [Past borrowing/repayment information; not a person's worth]
5. A \$600 essential repair is paid from \$800 of reserves. What remains, and what did the reserves accomplish? [\$200; they covered the cost]

For prompts 1, 2, 3 and 5, score one point for the complete answer shown. For prompt 4, score one point for identifying borrowing/repayment history. Record 0-5 before and after. Ask an equivalent new-dollar example at the end to check transfer; repeating questions can improve scores through familiarity.

Record anonymously	Observation
Participant code / device	_____
Before / after score (0-5)	_____
Could name the strategy target?	Yes / With help / No
Could explain one tradeoff?	Yes / With help / No
Controls or display blocked play?	_____
Clearest moment (own words)	_____
Most confusing moment	_____

Report invitations, starts, completions and paired scores separately. Include withdrawals and device failures. Use counts and examples; do not claim that a small, uncontrolled pilot proves improved long-term financial outcomes. Ask permission before quoting someone publicly; remove identifying details.

Make room for the learner.

Prepare one complete session before inviting a group. Use the current website and these fictional figures; never ask participants to upload bank statements.

Before the session

Open the site and check that the calculator connects. Try the household example and confirm it produces the expected \$600 remaining and 0.5 months of reserves. Test Debtbreak on the actual device and browser: its 3D battlefield needs working WebGL. Check keyboard or touch controls, sound preference and screen readability.

If the device or controls get in the way

Pause. Offer a larger screen, more time, or a facilitator controlling movement while the learner names the allocation and target. If 3D is unavailable, use the worksheet and the working money map; the site also has 2D arcade games. Record this as an adapted session, not a completed Debtbreak playthrough. No participant should be ranked by reaction speed.

Keep the financial meaning visible

Ask “Which account are you paying, and why?” when a shot lands. Ask “What are the reserves protecting now?” after a strike or repair. When payday arrives, explain that remaining debt continues into the next period. When both debts clear, review interest, payments freed and reserves rather than stopping at the victory animation.

Protect the conversation

Use fictional examples for group or Discord discussions. Let participants choose how much of their own story to share. A private channel is still visible to people with access; it is not a confidential financial-counseling room. Move requests for personal financial advice to an appropriate qualified service.

Send one useful report

Use “Share beta feedback” in the arcade. Include device/browser, the moment that became clearer, and the action that caused confusion. The form opens an email draft or copies text; it does not attach financial inputs or send automatically.

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Start: [Vi\\$ion website and games](#)